Crouzeix: Folie à Deux

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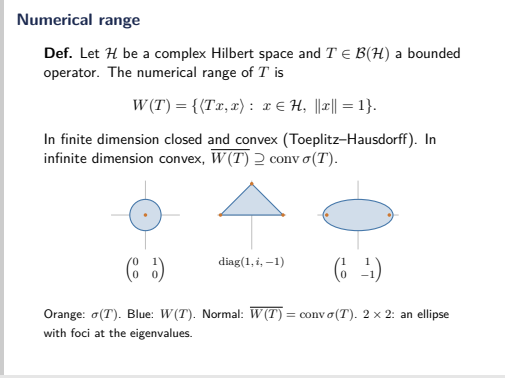
October 2026

bnic101.github.io/crouzeix-folie-a-deux

Two proofs, July 2026. Same method. Both credit ChatGPT.

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Numerical range



[3 min] $\langle Nx, x\rangle = x_2\bar{x}_1$, modulus $\leq \frac{1}{2}$, every value in the disc attained. Minor axis of the ellipse: $|t_{12}|$ in Schur form. Hilbert space case: compress to Krylov subspaces. Website: more examples, $\|T\|/w(T)$.

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Spectral sets

Spectral sets

Def. A set $S \subseteq \mathbb{C}$ is called a K-spectral set for an operator $T \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ if

$$\|p(T)\| \leq K \sup_{z \in S} |p(z)| \qquad \forall\, p \in \mathbb{C}[z].$$

(S bounded, polynomially convex.)

von Neumann's inequality. The disc is a spectral set for any contraction:

$$\|p(T)\| \leq \sup_{z \in \mathbb{D}} |p(z)|, \qquad \|T\| \leq 1.$$

(Also the closed half plane if $\operatorname{Re} T = \frac{T+T^*}{2} \geq 0$.)

von Neumann	Sz.-Nagy
function theory	dilation theory
Blaschke products	unitary dilation of T: $p(T) = P_{\mathcal{H}}\, p(U)|_{\mathcal{H}}$

[3 min] von Neumann: reduce to Blaschke products, Möbius maps by hand. Sz.-Nagy: compression of a unitary. Same split for the two 2026 proofs.

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Crouzeix conjecture

Crouzeix conjecture

Conjecture (Crouzeix 2004)

Let T be a bounded operator on a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$. The numerical range $\overline{W(T)}$ is a 2-spectral set for T.

Remark. This conjectured bound is sharp:

$$W\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} = D(0,\tfrac{1}{2}), \qquad p(z) = z, \qquad \left\| \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \right\| = 1 = 2 \cdot \tfrac{1}{2}.$$

Antecedents.

- von Neumann, only for contractions.
- Okubo–Ando 1975, Berger–Stampfli 1967: the disc is a 2-spectral set. Via 2-dilations: $W(T) \subset \overline{\mathbb{D}}$ iff $T^n = 2V^*U^nV$ (Berger).

Crouzeix 2004: true for 2×2, with equality only when $W(T)$ is a disc.

[3 min] Constant 2 for the disc is a theorem, not a triviality: Berger–Stampfli need $p(0) = 0$, Okubo–Ando remove it. 2×2: exact constant as a function of the eccentricity.

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Constants

Constants

Ω bounded convex, smooth boundary, $W(T) \subset \Omega$.

$$C_\Omega := \sup\{\|f(T)\| : \ W(T) \subset \Omega, \ \|f\|_\infty \le 1\}.$$

Delyon–Delyon	1999	$C_\Omega < \infty$	depends on Ω
Crouzeix	2004	2	only for 2×2
Crouzeix	2007	11.08	uniform in Ω
Crouzeix–Palencia	2017	$1+\sqrt{2}$	completely bounded
Jin	27 July 2026	2	function theory
Lorist–Schwenninger	Aug 2026	2	dilation theory

Technique, 1999 to 2026: the double layer potential. Shrinking Ω to $\overline{W(T)}$, $\sup_\Omega C_\Omega \le 2$ is the conjecture.

[2 min] Delyon–Delyon: constant from diameter^2/area. Crouzeix 2007: hard estimates on the Cauchy transform. Crouzeix–Palencia: six pages, survives matrix-valued f. Nine years, then two proofs in a week.

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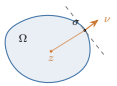
Double layer potential

Double layer potential

$\Omega \subset \mathbb{C}$ open bounded convex, smooth boundary, $\overline{W(T)} \subset \Omega$. $A(\Omega)$: holomorphic on Ω, continuous on $\overline{\Omega}$. $C(\partial\Omega)$: continuous on $\partial\Omega$. Sup norms. For $\sigma \in \partial\Omega$ let $\nu = \nu(\sigma)$ be the outward pointing normal; for $z \in \Omega$ the double layer potential is

$$\mu(\sigma, z) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\Big(\underbrace{\frac{\nu}{\sigma - z}}_{\text{first layer}} + \underbrace{\frac{\bar{\nu}}{\bar{\sigma} - \bar{z}}}_{\text{second layer}} \Big)$$

$= \frac{1}{\pi} \operatorname{Re} \frac{\nu}{\sigma - z}$. First layer: the Cauchy kernel.



- $\mu\, ds = \frac{1}{\pi}\, d\arg(\sigma - z)$: the angle at which z sees $d\sigma$.
- $\mu \geq 0$: z inside every supporting line.
- $\int_{\partial\Omega} \mu\, ds = 2$ for $z \in \Omega$; 1 for $z \in \partial\Omega$.

Why use? The Cauchy layer leads to a bound on $f(z)$. If we can control the conjugate we win. (Adjoint under the functional calculus.)

[4 min] Twice the real part of the Cauchy kernel. Mass 2 inside, 1 on the boundary: Gauss jump, which gives continuity of the Cauchy transform of $\bar{f}$ up to $\partial\Omega$ (Neumann). Only place $W(T) \subset \Omega$ is used. Website: drag z; push it to the boundary.

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Double layer potential, cont.

[3 min] $\mu(\sigma, T) \geq 0$: $\langle Tx, x\rangle \in \Omega$ gives $\operatorname{Re} \bar{\nu}(\sigma - T) \geq 0$; conjugate by the resolvent. Mass $2I$: Cauchy's formula plus its adjoint. First layer of $S(f, T)$ is $f(T)$; second layer is the adjoint of the Cauchy integral of $\bar{f}$, not of f.

Double layer potential, cont.

Let

$$C(f,T) = \frac{1}{2\pi i}\int_{\partial\Omega} f(\sigma)(\sigma - T)^{-1}\, d\sigma \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$$

and

$$S(f,T) = C(f,T) + C(\bar{f},T)^* \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H}).$$

By definition S is the function calculus integration against the double layer potential $\mu(\sigma, z)$, i.e.

$$S(f,T) = \int_{\partial\Omega} f(\sigma)\, \mu(\sigma,T)\, ds,$$

with $\mu(\sigma,T) = \frac{1}{\pi}\operatorname{Re}[\nu(\sigma)(\sigma - T)^{-1}] \geq 0$ and $\int \mu\, ds = 2I$.

Lemma (Crouzeix–Palencia 2017)

For $f \in C(\partial\Omega)$, $\|S(f,T)\| = \|f(T) + C(\bar{f},T)^*\| \leq 2\|f\|_{\partial\Omega}$.

Positivity, mass $2I$, Cauchy–Schwarz. So the question we must answer is: how does $\|S(f,T)\|$ control $\|f(T)\|$? In particular, can we estimate $C(\bar{f},T)^*$ or make it vanish all together?

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Positivity and the double layer formula

[3 min] Website: $f(z)$ and the companion as vectors; $\Phi(f)(z)$ stays in the convex hull of $f(\partial\Omega)$. Disc: companion constant, so Berger–Stampfli is the identity read off. Extremal f is a Blaschke product (Crouzeix 2004, Nevanlinna–Pick).

Positivity and the double layer formula

Consider

$$2\Phi(f) := f(T) + C(\tilde{f}, T)^* = f(T) + \alpha(f)(T)^*,$$

where

$$\alpha(f)(z) = \frac{1}{2\pi i}\int_{\partial\Omega} \frac{\overline{f(\sigma)}}{\sigma - z}\, d\sigma.$$

Note that $\alpha : A(\Omega) \to A(\Omega)$ is antilinear and $\alpha(1) = 1$.

Positivity of Φ says $2\|\Phi(f)\| \le 2\|f\|_{\partial\Omega}$: the result from the previous slide, found in Crouzeix–Palencia.

Scalar case: $2\Phi(f)(z) = f(z) + \overline{\alpha(f)(z)}$, holomorphic plus anti-holomorphic. Disc: $\alpha(f) = \overline{f(0)}$, a constant.
Crouzeix–Palencia: estimate the companion, $\|\alpha(f)\| \le \|f\|$. Gives $1 + \sqrt{2}$.

An alternate approach (not taken by either ChatGPT proof) is to "hack" the formula by studying extremal functions: f extremal, $\|f(T)\| \le \|2\Phi(f)\|$, which proves Crouzeix. (Bickel, Gorkin, Greenbaum, Overton.)

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Crouzeix–Palencia, $1+\sqrt{2}$

[4 min] Insert $T^* = (T + g(A)^*)^* - g(A)$ in the middle: first piece $\leq 2K^3$ by positivity, second $(fgf)(A)T^*$, $\leq K^2$ by the lemma. Example: $T^n = T$, $f(T) = \begin{pmatrix} f(1) & f(1)-f(0) \\ 0 & f(0) \end{pmatrix}$, $h(T) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$.

Crouzeix–Palencia, $1+\sqrt{2}$

$K = C_\Omega$, $\|f\| \leq 1$, $T = f(A)$, $g = \alpha(f)$, $\|g\| \leq \|f\|$ (Ω convex).

$$TT^*TT^* = T\left(T + g(A)^*\right)^* TT^* - (fgf)(A)\,T^*$$

$$K^4 \leq 2K^3 + K^2, \qquad K \leq 1+\sqrt{2}.$$

(Ransford–Schwenninger)

Uses only $\|f(A) + g(A)^*\| \leq 2$ and $\|g\| \leq \|f\|$. Sharp under these (Ransford–Schwenninger 2018):

$$T = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \Omega = D(0,\tfrac{1}{4}) \cup D(1,\tfrac{1}{4}),$$

$g = -f(0)$, $-f(1)$ on the two discs; $h = \mp 1$: $\|h(T)\| = 1+\sqrt{2}$. Not a counterexample: $W(T) \not\subset \Omega$.

Here $g(1) = -1$. The Cauchy transform: $\alpha(1) = 1$. Unused information: α is unital.

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Equivalent formulation

Equivalent formulation

Theorem (Twisted real part)

Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a unital commutative operator algebra, let $\theta : \mathcal{A} \to \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ be a bounded homomorphism and let $\alpha : \mathcal{A} \to \mathcal{A}$ be a unital antilinear map such that the unital linear map

$$\theta_\alpha : \mathcal{A} \to \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H}), \qquad a \mapsto \tfrac{1}{2}(\theta(a) + \theta(\alpha(a))^*)$$

is contractive. Then $\|\theta\| \le 2$.

- Ransford–Schwenninger (2018) show that the twisted real part theorem ⇒ Crouzeix.
- Michael Hartz (2026) proves the theorem using Jin's ChatGPT solution.
- $\theta(f) = f(T)$, α the Cauchy transform: $\theta_\alpha = \Phi$.
- Unital and contractive ⇒ positive: $\operatorname{Re} a \ge 0 \Rightarrow \operatorname{Re} \theta_\alpha(a) \ge 0$.

[2 min] Numerical range and Cauchy transform gone; what remains is positivity of the twisted real part. Both proofs establish this: Hartz as stated, Lorist–Schwenninger with "completely positive".

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Function theory

Function theory

Theorem (Holomorphic → resolvent transfer; Jin, operator form Hartz)

Let $T \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ with $\sigma(T) \subset \overline{\mathbb{D}}$. Let $H : \mathbb{D} \to \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ be a holomorphic function such that $H(0) = I$ and $\operatorname{Re} H(z) \geq 0$ for all $z \in \mathbb{D}$. Assume that

$$H(z) - (I - zT)^{-1}$$

commutes with T^* for all $z \in \mathbb{D}$. Then $\|T\| \leq 2$.

- $H(z) - (I - zT)^{-1} = 0$: $\operatorname{Re}(I - zT)^{-1} \geq 0$ iff $W(T) \subset \overline{\mathbb{D}}$ (Berger); conclusion is Okubo–Ando.
- Hartz shows that holomorphic → resolvent transfer ⇒ twisted real part: $T = \theta(a)$, $c_z = (1 + za)(1 - za)^{-1}$, $H(z) = \theta_\alpha(c_z)$. Then $\operatorname{Re} H \geq 0$ and $H(z) - (I - zT)^{-1} = \frac{1}{2}(\theta(\alpha(c_z))^* - I)$, an adjoint from the commutative algebra $\theta(\mathcal{A}) \ni T$.
- Concretely $\Delta(w) = \sum_{m \geq 1} w^m \alpha(f^m)(T)^*$: every power of f at once.

[4 min] H: Carathéodory function normalised at 0. Class C_ρ: $(\rho-2)I+2\operatorname{Re}(I-zT)^{-1} \geq 0$; $\rho = 2$ is $w(T) \leq 1$. Cayley transform has positive real part; unital contraction preserves it; $\theta(c_z) = 2(I - zT)^{-1} - I$. Crouzeix–Palencia used the identity once.

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Proof

Proof

$\Delta(z) := H(z) - (I - zT)^{-1}$, $R(z) := (I - zT)^{-1}$. On $H^2 \otimes \mathcal{H}$: $\operatorname{Re} M_H \geq 0$, $M_H = M_R + M_\Delta$.

$N_W := \{F = \sum F_n z^n : \ \sum W^n F_n = 0\}$, $\sigma(W) \subset \mathbb{D}$.

- $\Delta(z)W = W\Delta(z) \Rightarrow M_\Delta N_W \subset N_W$.
- $\Delta(0) = 0$, Γ the kernel of N_W at $0 \Rightarrow \Gamma^* M_\Delta \Gamma = 0$.

$W = \frac{1}{2}T^*$:

$$\Gamma^*(M_R + M_R^*)\Gamma = \Gamma^*(M_H + M_H^*)\Gamma \geq 0.$$

$P = \sum 4^{-n} T^{*n} T^n$, $Q = \sum 2^{-n} T^{*n} T^n$, $Y = Q - P \geq \frac{1}{4} T^* T$:

$4Y - YP - PY \geq 0 \ \Rightarrow \ P \leq 2I \ \Rightarrow \ T^*T \leq T^*PT = 4(P - I) \leq 4I.$

Jin: sample the Herglotz kernel of H at $\lambda_i/2$ and at 0.

[4 min] Functions vanishing at an operator point form an "ideal" when Δ commutes with W; kernel at 0 kills M_Δ since $\Delta(0) = 0$. Defect removed exactly, not estimated. Weights $4^{-n}, 2^{-n}$ from sampling radius $\frac{1}{2}$. Appendix: $\Gamma = K_0 - K_W P^{-1}$, eigenvector argument, Stein $P = I + \frac{1}{4} T^* P T$.

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Dilation theory

Lemma (Lorist–Schwenninger, ChatGPT)

Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a Hilbert space and $T \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$. Suppose there exists a Hilbert space $\mathcal{K}$, a contraction $Q \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{K})$ and an isometry $V \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H}, \mathcal{K})$ such that the operators

$$E_n := 2V^*Q^{*n}V - T^{*n}, \qquad n \in \mathbb{N},$$

are uniformly bounded and commute with T. Then $\|T\| \leq 2$.

- $E_n = 0$: 2-dilation of T^*, $\|T\| \leq 2$.
- $\mathcal{K} = L^2(\partial\Omega, ds; \mathcal{H})$, $Vx = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\mu(\cdot, T)^{1/2}x$, $Q = M_f$, $\|f\|_\infty = 1$, $T = f(A)$:
  $V^*Q^nV = \Phi(f^n), \qquad E_n = 2\Phi(f^n)^* - f(A)^{*n} = \alpha(f^n)(A).$
- E_n commutes with $f(A)$; $\|E_n\| \leq \|\theta\|\|\alpha\|$. Hence $\|f(A)\| \leq 2$.
- Stinespring for Φ; V isometric since $\int \mu \, ds = 2I$. $\|\alpha\| \leq 1$ not used.

[4 min] A genuine dilation of Φ, a perturbed 2-dilation of $f(A)$, error exactly the companion. Commutes: same functional calculus. Bounded: Crouzeix 2007 had 9.08. Abstract form: θ_α completely positive $\Rightarrow \|\theta\| \leq 2$ (Arveson, Stinespring).

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Proof

Proof

$\kappa := \|T\| > 1$, $T^*Tx = \kappa^2 x$, $\|x\| = 1$ (ultrapower).

$$m_n := \mathrm{Re}\langle E_n T^n x, x\rangle, \qquad u := Q^*VTx - \kappa Vx.$$

$$\|u\|^2 \le 2\kappa^2 - \kappa^3 - \kappa m_1 \qquad (n = 1)$$

$$\kappa m_1 \ge -\frac{\|u\|^2}{(\kappa-1)^2} \qquad \text{(telescope } \kappa m_n - m_{n+1},\ \text{all } n)$$

$$\|u\|^2(1 - (\kappa-1)^{-2}) \le \kappa^2(2-\kappa).$$

First line alone: $\kappa \le 1 + \sqrt{1 - m_1}$.
$\|\alpha\| \le 1 \Rightarrow m_1 \ge -1 \Rightarrow 1 + \sqrt{2}$. $m_1 < 0$ for some 3×3.

[4 min] u: failure of VTx to be a κ-eigenvector of Q^*. Upper bound: $n = 1$ only; $m_1 = \mathrm{Re}\langle (f\alpha(f))(A)x, x\rangle$, central since Crouzeix–Palencia. Lower bound: commutation plus the identity for $n+1$, summed with weights κ^{-n+1}. $m_1 \ge 0$ would finish; false in general. Appendix: both estimates.

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Un and Deux

[3 min] Same positivity (Carathéodory function / Stinespring), same packaging of all powers, same companion, same commutation hypothesis; compression vs. telescoping.

Un and Deux

	Un	Deux
positivity	$\operatorname{Re} H \geq 0$	$\Phi = V^*\pi(\cdot)V$
all powers	$H(w) = I + 2\sum_m w^m \Phi(f^m)$	E_n, all n
companion	$\sum_m w^m \alpha(f^m)(T)^*$	$\alpha(f^n)(T)$
used	commutes with T^*	commutes with T
removal	$\Gamma^* M_\Delta \Gamma = 0$	telescoping

Crouzeix–Palencia use the *size* of the companion, $\|\alpha(f)\| \leq \|f\|$: sharp at $1+\sqrt{2}$. Un and Deux use its *location*, the commutative algebra $\{g(T)\} \ni f(T)$. Its size is never used.

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The canary

[2 min] Read as written. Proofs written and checked by the authors.

The canary

What the papers say the model did.

- Jin: ChatGPT proposed sampling the Herglotz kernel at $\lambda_i/2$ and adding the origin sample that cancels the correction.
- Lorist–Schwenninger: GPT-5.6, 25–26 July, asked for an improvement in estimates involving the iterates f^n. Pointed at $\Phi(f^{n+1})^* f(A)x - \|f(A)\|\Phi(f^n)^* x$, controlled uniformly in n by the quantity behind m_1. Lemma abstracted from that. Saw Jin's preprint 28 July.
- Hartz: ChatGPT to discuss Jin's preprint.

Same step twice: one $f \to$ all f^n, applied to the companion.

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Completely bounded

[3 min] Both papers say so explicitly. Fill in the reference.

Completely bounded

Conjecture

For every $m \geq 1$ and $F = [f_{ij}] \in M_m(A(\Omega))$, $\|F(T)\| \leq 2 \sup_{z \in \Omega} \|F(z)\|$.

- Equivalently $f \mapsto f(T)$ has cb-norm ≤ 2. Paulsen: T similar to an operator with $\overline{W(T)}$ a complete spectral set.
- Known: $1 + \sqrt{2}$ (Crouzeix–Palencia); 2 for discs, weighted shifts (Crouzeix–Greenbaum 2025).
- $M_m(A(\Omega))$ is not commutative. Un and Deux need the companion to commute with $f(T)$; Crouzeix–Palencia need only $\|\alpha\| \leq 1$, which survives.
- Last week: [reference]. OpenAI SlopDrop (Burnstein, Iosevich, Krause, Yavicoli).

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